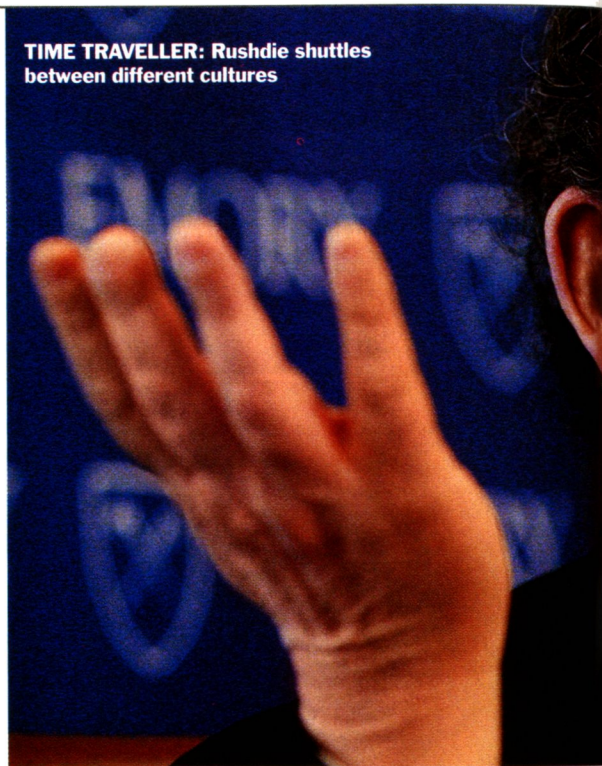


revolution, condemn the blasphemer to death. On St Valentine's Day, 1989, Rushdie vanished, and his life became an allegory. He lost the world, and became its most famous writer; and it was as if his life story was miming his own imagination. One thing that he didn't lose was the story. Stories kept him alive in exile, that "soulless country" the imaginary imam was so aware of. Sir Salman, at 60, is no longer the writer fettered. He is not restrained by national boundaries, and even though India is the syntax of his narrative, he, like Milan Kundera, is a world novelist. His journeys are semaphored by history, mythology and memory.

And look where he has reached. His new novel, *The Enchantress of Florence* (Jonathan Cape; 359pp; Rs 595), is what we may call the grandeur of return. Between East and West, in Planet Rushdie, there is no hyphen. It's always a comma, a pause, a blur. In this extravagantly accessorised novel set in Akbar's court and Machiavelli's Florence, the distance between East and West is reduced by a huge secret, a beautiful betrayal, a story woven out of the grey strands of history. One day, a yellow-haired foreigner wearing a coat of coloured leather lozenges gallops into the court of Akbar, the Great Mughal, "Shelter of the World", and entraps him in a story, for "witchcraft requires no potions, familiar spirits or magic wands. Language upon a silvered tongue affords enchantment enough." The stranger—adventurer, charlatan and storyteller—calls himself Mogor dell'Amore, the Mughal of Love, and claims to be Akbar's relative by blood. More seductively, his story brings to life the hidden princess of the Mughal era, the one who has become Angelica, "the princess of Cathay and India, the most beautiful woman in the world, and an enchantress beyond compare."

Her life begins as Qara Koz, Lady Black Eyes, the younger sister of Babar, Akbar's grandfather. Unlike her elder sister Khanzada, she, along with her slave companion, the Mirror, refuses to return to her defeated brother when released by her captor, and in the end reaches Florence as Angelica, with her Janissary lover, the mighty warrior Argalia, wielder of the enchanted lance. In the lovers' story of conquests, escape, seduction and sorcery merges the larger story of two worlds, separated by geography but united by the passion plays of history: "This may be the curse of the human race. Not that we are so different from one another, but that we are so alike." Rushdie, like an inspired fabulist, achieves the impossible by turning the tale of two cities—Akbar's Sikri and Machiavelli's Florence—into a narrative of perpetual reinvention. Speaking by phone from New York, he shares with INDIA TODAY the joy of discovery: "I had the original idea 10 years ago, when I was asked to write an introduction for a

TIME TRAVELLER: Rushdie shuttles between different cultures



new edition of *Babarnama*. I immediately knew that I didn't know enough to write the book. I was quietly reading and researching while writing the last two novels." When he finished *Shalimar the Clown*, he did intensive research for more than a year. "When I was reading about the era, I came across the true story of the princess who was given up to a warlord. She was supposed to be the great beauty of that age. Then I read Ludovico Ariosto's poem *Orlando Furioso*. Its main plot was about an Indian princess who mysteriously shows up in Europe." It was left to him the challenge of "inventing the princess who didn't exist". As a writer, Rushdie admits, he "had a long standing interest" in the Florence of Machiavelli and the court of Akbar, though "it never occurred to me that they would be in the same novel."

In *The Enchantress of Florence*, one mirrors the other. If Garcia Marquez in *The General in His Labyrinth* makes Simon Bolivar, the Liberator, lesser than his historical size, Rushdie in *The Enchantress* makes the Grand Mughal an exaggeration of his historical self. His court is a menagerie of wits and whores, panegyrists and concubines, wise men and spies. Queens float like ghosts, and among them is



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